

After a Record-Breaking Debut, 'The Other Bennet Sister' Returns with a Three-Part Holiday Special

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In a delightful twist for Jane Austen fans, the **sleeper hit** 'The Other Bennet Sister' is returning with a three-part Christmas specialalthough don't expect sleigh bells and mistletoe. The **Regency** era, when Austen set her novels, didn't celebrate Christmas with Victorian **fervor**. Instead, the special will dive into the 'what happens next' after Mary Bennet's wedding to Tom Hayward. 'Jane Austen always pulls the camera away at the point of marriage,' explains executive producer Jane Tranter. 'We were interested in seeing what life was going to be like for the Haywards.' The series, which follows the overlooked middle Bennet sister, became a **phenomenon**. It drove five times more new subscribers to BritBox in its first five weeks than any previous launch, and over 40% of active subscribers have watched it. In the UK, it was the biggest drama launch since May 2025, with 7.3 million viewers in 28 days. The special will be written by Sarah Quintrell and directed by Asim Abbasi, both key to the original series. Ella Bruccoleri returns as Mary, alongside 'a host of other familiar faces.' Filming begins this summer in Wales, with a likely holiday release. Tranter hints at a springtime **aesthetic**: 'Our world exists when the hedgerows are blooming, when the blossom is out. It's a very attractive bonnets, bows, bouquets kind of feel.' While no official date is set, Tranter smiled, 'Wouldn't it be lovely? Yes. It would be very special.' For those who rooted for the **bookish** Bennet, this is a chance to see her navigate the complexities of married lifea path Austen herself never explored. All ten episodes of the original series are streaming now on BritBox.

Word Treasure

sleeper hit -- A show or movie that becomes hugely popular even though few people expected it to succeed before its release.

Regency -- The period in British history from 1811 to 1820, known for its distinctive fashion, architecture, and strict social rules.

fervor -- Intense and passionate excitement or enthusiasm about something.

phenomenon -- Something that becomes extraordinarily popular and widely talked about in a short time.

aesthetic -- A particular visual style or look that creates a specific mood or feeling.

bookish -- Someone who loves reading and studying, often seen as quiet, thoughtful, or intellectual rather than outgoing.

Background you need

Jane Austen published *Pride and Prejudice* in 1813, introducing the world to the five Bennet sisters. While Elizabeth (the witty protagonist) and Jane (the beautiful eldest) have inspired countless film and TV adaptations, Mary -- the middle sister -- has historically been portrayed as pedantic, plain, and overlooked. The *Other Bennet Sister*, based on Janice Hadlow's 2020 novel, reframes Mary as a sympathetic character pursuing her own happiness on her own terms.

The show's success on BritBox (a subscription streaming service specializing in British television, launched in 2017 by the BBC and ITV) mirrors a broader cultural hunger for period dramas that explore previously sidelined female perspectives, much like *Bridgerton* or the reimagined *Sanditon*.

The Regency era (1811-1820), when Austen wrote, was a time of rigid social hierarchy where marriage was often a financial necessity for women rather than a purely romantic choice. The article's distinction between Regency and Victorian Christmas is historically accurate: Christmas as we know it -- with decorated trees, cards, and crackers -- was popularized much later, during Queen Victoria's reign (1837-1901), largely due to Prince Albert importing German Christmas traditions.

The three-part holiday special format has deep roots in British television, where Christmas specials of beloved series -- from *Doctor Who* to *Downton Abbey* -- often draw the year's highest ratings. Filming in Wales continues a long tradition of using the British countryside to stand in for Austen's fictional Hertfordshire and Derbyshire settings.

Break it down

HOOK: A delightful twist for Jane Austen fans -- a Christmas special unlike any other

+ SUBVERSION: 'don't expect sleigh bells and mistletoe'

HISTORICAL CONTEXT: Regency Christmas vs. Victorian Christmas

+ CLARIFICATION: The Regency era didn't celebrate with Victorian fervor

PLOT DIRECTION: What happens after Mary Bennet's wedding to Tom Hayward

+ CREATIVE RATIONALE: 'Jane Austen always pulls the camera away at the point of marriage'

+ SOURCE: Executive producer Jane Tranter explains the narrative vision

SUCCESS EVIDENCE: The show's phenomenon status established with data

+ SUBSCRIBER DATA: 5x more new BritBox subscribers in 5 weeks vs. any prior launch

+ ENGAGEMENT DATA: Over 40% of active subscribers watched it

+ RATINGS DATA: 7.3 million UK viewers in 28 days -- biggest drama launch since May 2025

PRODUCTION DETAILS: The special's confirmed creative team

+ WRITER: Sarah Quintrell (original series writer)

+ DIRECTOR: Asim Abbasi (original series director)

+ STAR: Ella Bruccoleri returns as Mary

+ LOCATION & TIMING: Filming in Wales this summer, likely holiday release

TONAL PROMISE: Springtime aesthetic teased by Tranter

+ QUOTE: 'Wouldn't it be lovely? Yes. It would be very special.'

CLOSING NOTE: All 10 original episodes available now on BritBox

Why it matters

The success of *The Other Bennet Sister* reflects a shift in what audiences want from historical stories -- not just grand romances, but nuanced explorations of characters who were previously dismissed as uninteresting. This mirrors how today's teens are rethinking who gets to be the hero of any story, whether in classic literature or in the media they consume every day.

Test what you remember

1. What type of special is being produced for 'The Other Bennet Sister'?
 - (A) A Halloween special
 - (B) A three-part Christmas special
 - (C) A summer beach special
 - (D) A New Year's Eve special
2. Why won't the special feature typical Christmas elements like sleigh bells?
 - (A) The production budget doesn't allow it
 - (B) The Regency era didn't celebrate Christmas with Victorian fervor
 - (C) The main character does not celebrate Christmas
 - (D) The story takes place during summer
3. How many more new subscribers did the show drive to BritBox in its first five weeks compared to previous launches?
 - (A) Twice as many
 - (B) Three times more
 - (C) Five times more
 - (D) Ten times more
4. Who will write the holiday special?
 - (A) Jane Tranter
 - (B) Asim Abbasi
 - (C) Sarah Quintrell
 - (D) Ella Bruccoleri
5. How many viewers did the original series attract in the UK within 28 days?
 - (A) 5.2 million
 - (B) 7.3 million
 - (C) 10.1 million
 - (D) 3.7 million
6. What aesthetic does executive producer Jane Tranter describe for the special?
 - (A) A dark, wintery feel with snow and ice
 - (B) A futuristic sci-fi look
 - (C) A springtime feel with blooming hedgerows, blossom, bonnets, bows, and bouquets
 - (D) An urban city setting with crowded streets

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: B 3: C 4: C 5: B 6: C

Questions to think about

- 1. Positive -- Creative opportunity for fans:** For fans of the original series, the special offers a rare chance to see a beloved character navigate married life -- a narrative space Austen herself deliberately left unexplored. The returning creative team's track record, including the show's record-breaking subscriber impact, suggests the special will maintain high-quality storytelling rather than being a rushed cash-in.
- 2. Negative -- Commercial calculation:** The announcement's heavy emphasis on subscriber numbers and viewing figures raises questions about whether the special is a genuine artistic continuation or a calculated business move. BritBox may be leveraging audience affection for Mary Bennet to retain subscribers in an increasingly crowded streaming market where period dramas are a key differentiator.
- 3. Neutral -- Cultural and historical framing:** The Regency-to-Victorian shift in Christmas traditions highlights how cultural practices we often assume are timeless are actually relatively recent inventions. Period dramas frequently navigate this tension between historical accuracy and modern audience expectations, and the article's early clarification about Christmas suggests the creative team is aware of this balance.
- 4. Forward-looking -- Expanding the Austen universe:** If the holiday special succeeds, it could open the door for more Austen-adjacent stories that explore what happens after the wedding -- a narrative territory the original novels deliberately left unexamined. This could reshape how streaming platforms approach literary adaptations, moving from faithful retellings toward speculative continuations that give voice to overlooked characters.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):
